Berlin, Acheson said he 'believed the president should himself give that question the most careful and private consideration, well before the time when the choice might present itself, and that he should reach his own clear conclusion in advance as to what he would do, and that he should tell no one at all what that conclusion was.'[26] According to Bundy, 'I believe nobody ever knew, just what Kennedy himself believed about the decision he would make if conventional battle were ever joined over access to Berlin in such a way that he was required to choose between defeat and the release of nuclear weapons.' [27]

Solemn commitments

On 25 July 1961 Kennedy delivered a televised speech from the Oval Office in which he described West Berlin as:

> the greatest testing place of Western courage and will, a focal point where our solemn commitments … and Soviet ambitions now meet in basic confrontation. The United States is there; the United Kingdom is there and France are there; the pledge of NATO is there – and the people of Berlin are there. It is as secure, in that sense, as the rest of us – for we cannot separate its safety from our own … we have given our word that an attack upon that city will be regarded as an attack upon us all. If we do not meet our commitments in Berlin, where will we later stand? If we are not true to our word there, all that we have achieved in collective security, which relies on these words, will mean nothing.[28]

The President sought an additional $3.25 billion dollars for the defence budget, a further commitment of six divisions to Europe, and the appropriation of an additional $207 million for a national fallout programme. Kennedy had recently created an Office of Civil Defense and had long been interested in protecting civil populations in a nuclear war. The additional resources, however, were of marginal significance, aside generating debates about whether to shoot your neighbours if they tried to